

The interface is very similar to Nero Burning ROM, with a few changes. On the lower half are vertically arranged tabs that can be used for changing the settings. The interface is best described as modest.

Performance

NeroLinux is a whole ten seconds faster than its Windows counterpart in burning both data CDs and disc images. It is also a little faster than K3b. But it taxes the system RAM pretty much to the same level as does the Windows version.

Site: <http://ww2.nero.com/us/nerolinux-prog.html>

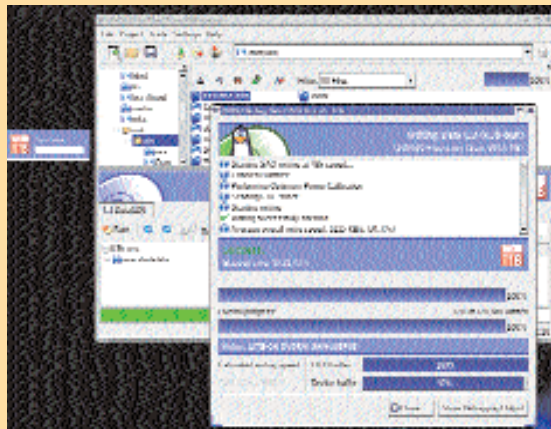
K3b.org K3b 0.12.10

K3b is open source. It's an application suited for the KDE environment, but it works well on GNOME as well. It is the top-seeded CD/DVD writing tool with plenty of features, provided your system is capable of handling it. That means that to have utilities such as the video encoder, your OS should have the library files to support the DVD and AVI/MPEG-4 formats.

Features

K3b lets you burn data CDs and DVDs, MP3, and audio CDs. It can burn video CDs as well. We liked the options K3b provides for erasing CD-RWs: you can choose to perform a Fast erase or a Full erase, and best of all, you can just erase the last recorded session!

Other nifty features are the audio ripping tool and the disc image loader. You can use the disc image loader to load and view the contents of an ISO file. The same can be done by use of



A tiny rectangular box stays on top of other applications indicating the progress of disc writing in K3b

commands, but the GUI and K3b makes the task very simple. Need to rip a DVD movie to the AVI format? The ripping tool for DVD is just a front-end, so you'll have to download and install the necessary source object files (*.so) to get rid of dependencies, if any. Thereafter, the task is pretty simple.

Ease Of Use

When it comes to installation, K3b will give a new Linux user a horrid time! The installer comes as a tarball, which means an archived and compressed (.tar.gz or .tar.bz2) set of files from which you need to configure and install the application. Just be prepared to do some reading, and eventually, learning! The advantage of a tarball is that it can be installed on any Linux distribution.

To install K3b, first uncompress and untar the downloaded file with one of these commands, depending on the type of file:

```
#tar -zxvf <filename>.tar.gz
or
#tar -jxvf <filename>.tar.bz2
```

Now change your directory to the directory where the files are uncompressed and untarred (the above command does both these functions) and run the configure script, which is `./configure.sh`. Always read the readme file before jumping to the configuration process.

If the configuration runs with out any errors, you might have a successful installation.

The entire installation process takes a long time, but the outcome is software best configured for your system hardware, which can't be achieved by ready-made installers.

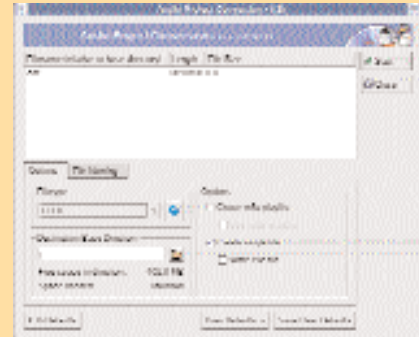
The interface looks good, and has a Wizard at the start of the application, displaying different burn projects.

An easy file browser is in the upper half of the interface, and the details of the burn project are below it. K3b displays a tiny icon in the corner of the screen showing burn progress.

The feel of K3b is undoubtedly better than that of NeroLinux, and is even better than that of some of the Windows software.

Performance

K3b consumes less system memory than NeroLinux, but



An audio converter is available in k3b and so is DVD ripper only if dependencies are cleared

takes a few extra seconds to complete a burn project.

There isn't a major difference in the performance levels of the two packages.

System resource usage is within prescribed limits. Neither application malfunctioned in our tests - this indicates they are stable releases.

Site: <http://k3b.org/>

Nero Or K3b?

K3b wins the race hands down—it's way ahead in terms of features! We don't understand why Ahead is distributing a paid version of Nero for Linux with such few features.

The only factor in favour of Nero is ease of installation. But K3b also has distribution-specific installer packages, so eventually, there's not much point using NeroLinux. Hats off to K3b.org and the open source community for their efforts!

In Conclusion

We hope we've alerted you to the fact that Nero is not the be-all and end-all of burning software. We've also tried to get across the point that you can do a lot more with burning software than just burn.

Memory usage is an important point—software that takes up less memory while burning is preferable, since you probably tend to do other things while a CD or DVD is burning.

You'll probably see Blu-ray and HD-DVD featuring prominently in our tests next time round.

In combination with the DVD-Writers shootout in this issue, we hope we've informed you of all you need in order to create perfect DVDs. So go ahead—organise, compile, burn! ☐

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